

Chapter 66: Behavioral Psychology and Operant Conditioning in George Orwell's *Animal Farm*: A Psychological Analysis

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Abstract

Animal Farm is a political allegory that criticizes the Russian Revolution and the rise of Stalinist totalitarianism. This chapter portrays *Animal Farm* as a psychological novel in connection to behavioural psychology and B.F. Skinner's operant conditioning. This study adopted a qualitative textual analysis of the novel and depicted the operant conditioning of behaviour through fear, reinforcement, punishment, propaganda, and environmental control. This chapter highlighted that Napoleon's authoritarian regime is well-maintained not because of political power but because of conditioning behaviour that practices obedience and oppression. The thematic analysis focuses on other key characters such as Boxer, Squealer, and the sheep to illustrate positive and negative reinforcement, punishment, their beliefs, actions, and absolute loyalty. The incessant use of slogans, exploitation of the Seven Commandments, propagation of information, and environmental control are the strategies that influenced collective behaviour and rusted critical thinking skills. By incorporating behavioural psychology in this novel, it is observed that manipulation paved the way to oppression and maintained authoritarian control. Besides, this chapter also highlighted political hegemony and mob psychology in relation to psychological analysis. To conclude, this study provides a conceptual and interpretative framework to analyse the political power, obedience, and operant conditioning in this novella, *Animal Farm*.

Keywords: Behavioural Psychology, Operant Conditioning, Punishment, Propaganda, and Reinforcement.

1. Introduction

Animal Farm is the most popular political novella written by the famous writer George Orwell in 20th-century English literature (Orwell, 1945; Rodden, 2007). It was written soon after the Second World War to express the manipulation of revolutionary ideas and the rise of an authoritarian regime (Orwell, 1945; Crick, 1980). Even though *Animal Farm* is a political allegory of the Russian Revolution, the author examined the universal dynamics of political power, manipulation of ideas, and environmental control too (Orwell, 1945; Newsinger, 1999). Furthermore, the author highlighted the exploitation of political authorities and its impacts on society. Basically, *Animal Farm* has been studied from political and historical perspectives, yet this chapter analyzes psychological perspectives profoundly to comprehend the human psyche. Behavioural psychology was developed by John B. Watson (Watson, 1913; Skinner, 1953) and later elaborated by B.F. Skinner, which argues that behaviour is learned through communication with the environment and refined by fear, punishment, reinforcement, and conditioning (Skinner, 1953; Skinner, 1974). Skinner's theory of Operant conditioning, behaviour may

be strong or weak according to its consequences (Skinner, 1953). The mechanisms and patterns may influence and control individuals as well as groups. This chapter scrutinizes *Animal Farm* through the perspectives of behavioural psychology in relation to Skinner's theory of Operant conditioning. It adopts qualitative textual analysis to explore the manipulation of ideas and the impacts of animal behaviour on this manipulation through rewards, fear, punishments, propaganda, and environmental control. These are the strategies used to maintain authoritative power. This chapter further investigates other characters, such as Boxer, Squealer, and the sheep, who are examples of behavioural manipulation of obedience and conditioned mob psychology. Moreover, it explores how the manipulation refines behaviour, oppresses individuals' thoughts, and slowly brings subjugation. This study is an interdisciplinary approach to investigate literary study with psychology, throwing light on the relevance of behavioural theory to comprehend both fictional narratives and societal norms.

2. Conceptual Framework

In the early 20th century, behavioural psychology emerged to observe the behaviours of humans and animals. John B. Watson was the founder of behaviorism, who strongly argued that the behaviours of humans and animals are shaped by environmental influences rather than primary instincts. Watson believed that behaviour is observed through communication with external forces and it can be measured, predicted, and modified. With Watson's theory, B.F. Skinner enlarged the concept of Operant conditioning, which concentrates on the impacts of behaviour in its consequences. According to B.F. Skinner, individuals repeat behaviours that produce positive outcomes, whereas they neglect behaviours that produce negative or undesirable consequences. Operant conditioning explores four major mechanisms to modify behaviours (Skinner, 1953) 1) positive reinforcement, 2) negative reinforcement, 3) positive punishment, and 4) negative punishment. 1) Positive reinforcement involves desirable outcomes, so repeated behaviour will happen. 2) Negative reinforcement involves the removal of undesirable outcomes and strengthens the behaviour. 3) Positive punishment focuses on reducing the undesirable behaviour by adding an unpleasant consequence, and 4) Negative punishment is not encouraging behaviour by withdrawing a valuable one. These are the mechanisms which has shown that behavioural responses are not unplanned but are systematically modified by environmental influences and consequences. Behavioural psychology highlighted the concept of environmental conditioning, which denotes social and physical environment plays a vital role in influencing individual and social behaviour. Individuals gradually respond in an expected way through repeated rewards, punishments, symbols, routines, and patterns. Environmental conditioning operates through propaganda, surveillance, intimidation, and manipulation of information, and the creation of patterns of obedience.

In *Animal Farm*, Orwell expresses Napoleon's manipulation of information to attain authoritarian power. Napoleon carefully manipulates the behavioural responses of the other animals through regulated rewards, fear, punishments, and propaganda. Faithful animals are rewarded with recognition, whereas rebels are punished with violence or excluded from the community. Squealer's repetition of slogans and the frequent revision of the Seven Commandments are the evidence for environmental conditioning that oppresses individuals' thinking and modifies collective attitudes. This shows clearly that *Animal Farm* encompasses the systematic conditioning of behaviour that reflects in the sustainability of political power.

3. Methodology

This study adopts an interpretative and analytical approach to investigate the literary text with psychological and social behaviour. Qualitative analysis is adopted to examine the study of language, characterization, symbolism, narrative structure, and ideological representation within the novel. This helps to comprehend the behavioural patterns in the text with reference to political and psychological facts.

Qualitative analysis is divided into close reading, character analysis, symbolic events, narrative progression, language and propaganda, contextual interpretative approach,

The textual analysis focuses on close reading to extract characters, interactions, dialogues, narratives, and symbolic representations meticulously, which illustrates behavioural conditioning. Particularly, the character Napoleon's passages and dialogues reveal the psychology of attaining power through rewards, punishments, fear, and propaganda. Old Major's speeches, the arguments of Squealer, Boxer's unquestioning trust, and the Sheep's repetition of chants are the greatest evidence of behavioural conditioning in *Animal Farm*.

Character analysis is another important factor to understand the psychological behaviour of the characters. In *Animal Farm*, each character is the symbolic representation of a political figure and also a behavioural refinement through environmental influences. Napoleon is known for his behavioural manipulation, reinforcement, fear, and punishment to maintain his political power. Squealer is responsible for reshaping collective memory. His repetitive messages refined the conditioned beliefs that changed into collective memory. Boxer, portrayed as an obedient character, believes that loyalty is rewarded, but it is not actually rewarded yet, misguided and exploited in the name of reward. The sheep's repeated slogans have brought out the collectiveness or mob psychology. By investigating all these characters, it is evident that beyond political allegorical interpretations, it has psychological mechanisms.

Symbolic and narrative events are to be analysed, on the other hand, to explore more about the behavioural patterns in this novella. For example, events such as the banishment of Snowball, building the windmill, gradual recreation of the Seven Commandments, public confessions and executions, and the last transformation of the pigs into human-like dictators. These narrative events indicated the process of behavioural conditioning through fear, obedience, and an adaptable mindset. This shows how these animals are changing internally due to the changes happening repeatedly in the environment. All these incidents happen in different places, but it has a cumulative outcome of behavioural and psychological patterns.

Language and propaganda are another important aspect to analyse the use of speeches, slogans, repetitions, which drastically change the mindset of the animals. This is another great piece of evidence for environmental conditioning. Behavioral psychology says that repeated disclosure may bring habitual responses. This can be seen in the novella through slogans such as "*Napoleon is always right*", and "*Four legs good, two legs bad*". The frequent modification of the Seven Commandments indicates that the functions of language also play the role of shaping memory, perception, thoughts, and social facts.

The Contextual interpretative approach focuses on the political perspective yet, this does not separate psychological patterns and political powers. Actually, authoritarian leadership is not only a military power or a political regime but also the systematic conditioning of individuals through fear, rewards, ideology, and environmental manipulation. Therefore, this methodology section facilitates an interdisciplinary bridge between literature and psychology and exhibits a narrative of how political systems are a behavioural process.

3.1 Operant Conditioning and Napoleon's Leadership

B.F. Skinner's Operant conditioning is reflected in Napoleon's strategy to sustain regime power in the *Animal Farm*. As Skinner's theory states, behaviour is modified based on the consequences, Napoleon systematically trained other animals to get into and maintain power by giving rewards, punishments, and manipulation. Orwell portrays through Napoleon that attained leadership not through violence but through planned behavioral responses. At the beginning, Napoleon portrays himself a committed leader of principles for Animalism. But, after attaining the power, Napoleon expelled Snowball with the help of his trained dogs, to establish his power in the Animal Farm. This incident shows that the behavioural regime that obedience is rewarded and the protest is punished severely. From the lens of behavioural psychology, it is clear that controlling consequences is more effective than controlling behaviour. Napoleon abolished public discussions, democratic debates instead of all the decisions he made by himself. This indicates that changing the mindset of the animals that questioning is unethical, and the unquestioning is obedience.

Another example for Napoleon's leadership is the usages of positive reinforcement to sustain his desired behaviours. The animals, especially pigs who are loyal to Napoleon receive all benefits like milk, fruits, and comfortable living but the other animals do not. This makes the other animals to forcefully accept the hierarchy by following other obeyed animals rather than questioning. Skinner states that verbal praise and recognition is more enough for reinforcement rather than material benefits. Napoleon's leadership is the example for this incident.

Napoleon also used negative reinforcement to create fear among the animals. The trained dogs of Napoleon reminds the consequences of rebellions. The other animals agree and obey to all his commands not because they like him or his commands, but they do fear the consequences of disobeying his commands. Thus, Orwell depicts that the power is being maintained through conditioning rather than physical force.

Napoleon also used environmental conditioning to refine collective behaviour in the *Animal Farm*. Through Squealer, he controls information, recreates the Seven Commandments, celebrating his leadership in public places are the mottos to collective behaviour of controlling the mob. Repeating all these regularly has brought changes in the mindset of the animals which helps Napoleon to sustain his political power and no animals turn against Napoleon and his ideas. On the whole, Napoleon controlled the animals not only by force but also by conditioning behaviour.

3.2 Reinforcement and Boxer's Obedience

In *Animal Farm*, the character Boxer is the strongest and most hardworking animal, very committed but exploited because of authority. In view of Skinner, Boxer's behaviour is not only innate but the

consequences of reinforcement that shapes his attitudes and behaviours. When the animals were against Mr. Jones, Boxer devoted himself to the Farm and even worked more hard to end the criticism, he always used to say and to follow the slogan “*I will work harder,*” this is Operant conditioning, when positive consequences are received, it is expected to get repeated ever (Skinner, 1953). Moreover, Boxer did not get any rewards, but only verbal appreciation for his more physical effort. Napoleon and Squealer often praised Boxer’s trustworthiness and it is a sign for the other animals to be followed like Boxer. Boxer’s thought is “*Napoleon is always right*”. The continuous hidden force on Boxer in the name of reward, allows Boxer to estimate the character of Napoleon.

Negative reinforcement is also seen in the farm, those who oppose Napoleon must underwent increased labour, insufficient food, continuous threat of punishment. To avoid criticism of the power, and suspicion more works were given and extract hard work from the animals in the farm. The construction of the windmill is the example for this conditioning. Excessive labor is extracted, in return provided inadequate food, yet Boxer never questioned the leadership instead they work more hard and put much more effort to prove their loyalty and maintain their verbal rewards and appreciations. As a result, Boxer was betrayed and his life ended in tragic. Through the lens of psychology the systematic behavioral conditioning can produce extraordinary levels of loyal, self-sacrifice, and obedience. On the whole, it is clear that when individuals are conditioned to be obedient above critical thinking, they become vulnerable to exploitation and manipulation.

3.3 Punishment and Fear as Instruments of Control

Punishment functions as an important element of B.F. Skinner’s theory of Operant conditioning by restraining behaviours considered objectionable (Skinner, 1953). Skinner differentiates punishment into positive punishment and negative punishment. Positive punishment involves showing an obnoxious consequence to avoid a behaviour whereas negative punishment involves eradicate the necessary stimulus to demotivate unnecessary actions (Skinner, 1953). Both the punishments are involved in this novella *Animal Farm*. During the public confessions, executions, and the trained dogs cruelty are the incidents noted for positive punishments. These are well-planned in advance to instill fear among the remaining animals. Negative punishment is involved in this novel not only through physical violence but depriving essential resources to them (Skinner, 1953). For instance, when foods were not given adequately Squealer describe reduction of food as “readujstments.” It is also be noted that the works were given doubled and reduce food which results to control the mob with force. Behavioural psychology comprehends that the continuous threat stimuli modify the long-term patterns of avoidance and dependence (Skinner, 1971). Suppression comes to the practice by controlling their behaviour. On the whole, Orwell indicates that public executions, cruelty of dogs, deprivation of essential resources and the regular threat these are forcefully given to them as a means of survival. As a result, the animals were obeying the ruler but not of loyalty but for fear of survival.

3.4 Propaganda and Behavioral Conditioning through Squealer

Squealer systematically refines the perceptions and aspects of animals through repeated slogans, misinterpret information and manipulation of the facts (Ellul, 1973; Jowett & O’Donnell, 2019). This shows that Squealer acts as a behavioural conditioner who reinforces obedience, discards independent

thoughts, and nurtures unquestioning trustworthiness to Napoleon's reign. Thus, Napoleon regime depend on not only physical force but also on psychological manipulation to sustain his government and political power. As Boxer insisted the slogan "*Napoleon is always right*," Squealer used slogans to manipulate language and memory of the animals. For example, Squealer misinterpret the information of Seven Commandments of Animalism for the welfare of pigs. The original commandment is "*No animal shall sleep in a bed*," is quietly changed into "*No animal shall sleep in a bed with sheets*," and the other slogan "*No animal shall drink alcohol*" is also changed into "*No animal shall drink alcohol to excess*." These changed versions exploit pigs' memory and restricted literacy. From a behavioral perspective the revised conditions are to be accepted as it is normal. Thus environmental stimuli gradually redefine the acceptance and expectations.

3.5 Environmental Control and Collective Conformity

John B. Watson clearly argued that environmental influential play a vital role in shaping individual behaviour (Watson, 1913). Besides, he emphasized that acquisition of behaviour is well-maintained through interactions with environmental stimuli and their consequences. This represented in Napoleon's approach in physical, social, and psychological aspects which produces collective conformity. Napoleon constantly cultivates the conditions of the animals' behaviour, beliefs, and attitudes until their obedience change into habitual (Bandura, 1977; Foucault, 1977).

The closing scene of the novel show the expression of environmental conditioning and collective conformity. At the beginning of the novel, pigs started revolution against humans, but at the end of the novel, pigs' imitated humans which is the corruption occurred in Revolution. At the beginning, they said "*Four legs are good, two legs are bad*". It shows that they started revolution against humans, but at the end they followed humans like walking like them, wearing clothes like them, and they shared dining to the neighboring farmers. All these activities of the pigs indicated the corruption of revolution. Even in the Seven Commandments, it is declared that "*All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others*" (Orwell, 1945; Arendt, 1951). This statement is quite contradictory and insisted dictatorship, authority, and inequality. Orwell reinforces this in the lines "*The creatures outside looked from pig to man, from man to pig.....but already it was impossible to say which was which*." This famous line insists that power without liability leads to corruption and the principles of equality will be devastated when leaders place their own interests above those of the people they claim to serve (Arendt, 1951; Foucault, 1977)

4. Conclusions

The famous writer George Orwell's Animal Farm is widely recognised as a political allegory of the Russian Revolution. This study analyses a profound psychological exploration of sustaining authority through behavioural conditioning (Skinner, 1953). It found B. F. Skinner's theory of operant conditioning, elements such as reinforcement, punishment, propaganda, and environmental control in this work Animal Farm.

Napoleon's leadership illustrates the use of positive and negative reinforcement as well as positive and negative punishment to safe obedience and eradicate opposition. Boxer's unquestioning loyalty is

reinforced through verbal appreciation and ideological rewards, while executions, the dog's coercion and the afraid of punishment oppress rebellion. Squealer's propaganda and manipulation of language and history forced to accept false narratives, replacing independent ideas with unquestioning acceptance.

The study concludes by stating that Orwell delineates authoritarianism as a **systematic process of psychological conditioning** rather than mere political oppression. The animals' accepted the inequality state of minds through sustained behavioural manipulation and but not a voluntary consent. By incorporating literary work with behavioral psychology, the analysis widens the interpretation of *Animal Farm*, expressing that Orwell's novella is both a timeless political allegory and a powerful psychological study of power, obedience, conformity, and ideological control.

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